FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

The name alone is ingenious. The cockroach, distinctly unglamorous, very many in number, powerless, but also strangely enduring, could stand in for the common Indian in self-mocking irony. Born as online satire, the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) spread with a speed no conventional political party could have engineered. From its virtual petridish, it sprang to life in real-world politics at Jantar Mantar, drawing tens of thousands of young Indians, gig workers and shanty town dwellers alongside YouTube influencers and students from elite colleges, the urban melding with the non-metropolitan. The tidal surge forced the Narendra Modi government into a rare retreat and a re-evaluation of its entire public outreach. A Union minister resigned, exam reform was fast-tracked. The prime minister himself took to Instagram. For a movement born as a joke, that is a serious opening chapter. The question this week's cover story asks is the one that matters most. What happens next?

All signs are that the youth league aims to climb up the ladder. The CJP has rolled out an agenda and put in place a rudimentary national organisation. Such an evolution logically culminates in a political party. Even its flock may find it a bit anti-climactic if it chooses to remain an amorphous youth movement, a pressure group, or an NGO. Getting into politics may attract jibes from the mainstream, but nothing about such an ambition is unjustified. India's Gen Z will yield a massive 380 million voters by 2029, a quarter of the electorate. Once an insignificant, apolitical band, it will become India's largest and perhaps most decisive generational bloc. Common concerns bind them, especially the scarcity of jobs. Their power was demonstrated in Tamil Nadu, when superstar Vijay, a political debutant, swept aside a strong traditional party purely on youth strength. The numbers and the precedent exist. There is nothing inherently implausible about a national occurrence of that kind. But what is plausible in theory is frequently destroyed in practice by India's messy, competitive political terrain. The CJP is moving with seeming awareness of the potential as well as the peril. Neither the ruling BJP, nor Opposition parties like the Congress, are likely to roll over and give right of way to a formation they see as an upstart. How then can it translate its start into a politics of lasting value? One that can make a difference?



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I have been watching Indian politics for 50 years. I have seen popular movements rise on genuine public anger and dissipate just as quickly when the anger had nowhere structural to go. I have seen others make the transition into a durable political force. The difference between the two is rarely passion. A movement needs three key ingredients to succeed: leadership, an agenda and an organisation that can communicate that agenda to the public and make it count. From Jayaprakash Narayan in the 1970s to Anna Hazare and Arvind Kejriwal in the 2010s, popular protest movements that made such a transition had charismatic figures who could become a rallying point. Abhijeet Dipke gives the CJP a likeable but unassuming helmsman who is still evolving from his past role as a backroom operator for the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP). His team, too, bears that imprint. The CJP has smartly expanded beyond the NEET controversy that ignited the whole movement. It now talks of the state of government schools, electoral reforms, corruption and institutional accountability across the board. These are real issues, but a mature political party needs more than a list of grievances.

It needs a blueprint for India's economy. How will jobs be created for the 12 million young Indians entering the labour market every year? How will the structural mismatch between education, skills and employment be resolved? Curing a tainted examination system will not by itself solve the stark asymmetries that Gen Z faces. A policy ethos cannot be an afterthought to an agitation. The CJP's agenda needs more sharpness, depth and cohesion than it currently has. They will also face the threat of the traditional parties hijacking their agenda, particularly the Congress, which has not had much traction for the issues it has picked up. Also, the might of the ruling party will rain on them.

Communication is where the CJP clearly scores. Speaking directly on Gen Z's favourite social media platforms, it can bypass the entire communication machinery of traditional parties. An Instagram reel reaches the grassroots in an instant. Its 'Kya Bolti Public?' campaign sets up a two-way channel, crowdsourcing governance themes and creating something resembling popular ombudsmanship. That is innovative and real. The question is whether all this raw digital energy can be harvested and processed into a coherent political product or whether it dissipates into a callow formation as similar movements did elsewhere.

India's political history does not inspire easy optimism. It does not foreclose the possibility either. We speak to enthusiasts and sceptics alike, examining whether a youth movement born in satire and validated by genuine public anger can make the difficult journey to political maturity. The CJP's growth pangs, whatever form they take, will offer a mirror to something larger. India is the youngest major country in the world. How it absorbs the political energy of that youth, productively or destructively, will shape the next decades of its democracy more than any single election.

The cockroach, it seems, has ambitions beyond survival.

(Aroon Purie)